

The social contract



The advent of a social contract establishing civil society meant an end to medieval feudalism.

In *Leviathan*, Hobbes contrasted the lawless state of nature with the political order of a civil society. In order to make the transition to such a society, he explained that there must be consent from all concerned – a social contract to give up ‘natural rights’ and hand power to an authority that imposes and enforces laws. Although a social contract necessarily restricts the freedom of individuals, it protects them from what Hobbes saw as the evils of lawlessness. Hobbes argued that authority should ideally be given to a single person – a monarch or even a tyrant was preferable to a chaotic society.

Other philosophers accepted the idea of a social contract, but disagreed with Hobbes’s preference for monarchy. John Locke, who had a less jaundiced

opinion of human nature and a suspicion of authority, argued for a more egalitarian system in which power is given by the consent of the governed to protect natural freedoms, giving them civil rights, including the right to remove tyrannical or ineffective government.